

University of California, Berkeley 2

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The closest thing to a startup you'll find inside of a company like Microsoft. At the leading edge of innovation, AI, and the home and birthplace of Copilot. If you've ever used it, worked with it, love it, you'd think of this person right here.

I just think of the whole team, the whole team. The whole Eden and team. Welcome.

Thank you, thank you so much for having me. There's been a lot of topics covered today. We've both heard.

You all have heard. And there's a lot to add in everything. And we want to take kind of a spin through some of the topics and touch on some new ones.

From the perspective that Ian has, which is both working inside large corporations, working as a small company, working in small companies, and through Google Tel Aviv, working with dozens or hundreds of startups over the course of his tenure there. And let's kind of start, if we can, with AI Native, the concept of AI Native, which is something you talk about a lot. And how you define what that means in a world where it's supposed to change the way that we do things.

In the last session, we were hearing about chat as the ultimate modality. It slices, it dices, it julienne fries. Is that the be-all and end-all? I don't know.

I'm not actually convinced that it is. I think it's got a good fit for the affordance of the technology. But if we rest on our laurels and say, chat is the best thing that can possibly be, that part I don't have confidence in.

I think one of the things that we were talking about earlier is this notion of when television was invented, what was the most popular form of serialized content? It was radio dramas. And so the first television show, so to speak, was they just put a camera in the room with the people recording the radio drama. So they'd have all the props that make the sounds, like when you pop a balloon to make a gunshot or whatever.

Because they didn't yet know the language of this new medium. And I think we're at a similar moment with AI. Back then with television, did they know that we would eventually have MTV Cribs? I don't think that was really obvious to them at the moment where radio was what people thought of.

And now here we are with AI and we're like, ah, chat is the be all and end all. No, maybe it's a radio drama. So yeah, I think there's a lot to be figured out there in terms of what is truly AI native.

And when I think about the ladder of value, the highest form of value is I don't know, and I never think about it. I walk into the kitchen and I want a salad, and oh look, there's my cutting board and some vegetables. It's just magically there, like an invisible butler.

I don't want to have to tell the butler, hey, fetch me the cutting board and the knife and the vegetables. Right now maybe we aren't able to do that yet. So okay, what's one step down in the ladder of value? Well, something that's guessing or estimating based on my prior interactions, what I'm going to do next.

That's maybe achievable today. So when we think about AI native, it's finding those moments and the modalities that match them. And this has also downstream effects on how we think about measuring products.

I'll give a concrete example. Now with AI, AI's gotten cheap enough and fast enough that we can afford to do variants. Like if I want to do a thing, I can tell AI, give me three different attempts at this thing.

And let's say I'm measuring how many of these variants, how many AI journeys result in success. If I'm looking at it and I say, well, we tried three and only one got accepted, I have a 33% acceptance rate, that sounds bad. But that optionality may be led to it happening at all.

Or the fact that we look down more roads and have that option to choose from the best among them, that's actually good. That's AI native. That's AI native thinking.

And so how are business measurements going to adapt to a world of plenty and abundance in trying things? That I think is maybe sort of a good example of what AI native is. I have a hard time defining it, but I know it when I see it. And that's kind of what I mean.

I think that's a great primer on AI native. It sounds like it's really how the user is interacting with it, with the base level, the experience, the UX, as we call it now. And if UX is, I guess the question is, is UX what makes AI the most, the crucial factor that makes user-facing AI really valuable? More valuable than, say, a chatbot or an agent encoder? Is it UX that unlocks AI for the user? I want to just say yes, but I need to caveat and say that as a UX person in my background, that maybe I'm the proverbial man with the hammer and every problem looks like a UX problem to me.

So take what I say with a big rock of salt. Yes, sometimes success with AI is about the technology. How good is the model? Are the models improved? How good are we at collecting the right context and selecting the right context to show to the models in order to elicit useful responses? At the end of the day, that's what I'm aiming for.

I ask the AI to do something, and then do I like what I got back? But sometimes improving those outcomes has nothing to do with the actual technology. It has to do with how am I teaching people? Especially at this moment, where there's this Overton window moving where people don't know how to use AI. Over and over again through the panels that I've heard today,

I've heard people say things like, listen, man, you just got to use it.

You got to use it in order to know. If you're not using it, then you don't know. And I get asked all the time by businesses, what can I do to increase the amount of value that I get out of the AI that I'm buying from you all? And I'm like, well, are you using it? You can't learn to drive from reading a book.

You got to get on the road. So that's a moment in time. That's not going to be here forever.

Like five years from now, everyone will have experienced some AI in some capacity in the same way that, whatever, if I showed blue underlined text to people in 1990, they wouldn't know what that means. But the same people in the year 2000 are like, oh, that's a link, right? That's what's changing. So I think finding the right UX really matters.

And maybe there's more than one answer there. It's like, what's the UX for that bridge period, right? Like when the cloud was new, we had all these startups helping businesses move to the cloud and feel safe in the cloud and do encryption at rest. And now banks are all just like, yeah, of course, everyone in the cloud.

So a lot of those kinds of businesses existed for a moment, and then they were gone. I actually saw several of them. It was kind of heartbreaking.

So, yeah? Yes. It was confirmation UX is critical. Back to GitHub Next and what you do.

It's a fascinating kind of incubator-style work within GitHub, which is itself a subsidiary of Microsoft, where you get to work on long bets. You get to explore innovation, thinking not six months ahead, like we've heard some of the panelists talk about what's everyone going to be doing in six months and what's the paradigm shift? You're thinking further down the road. What are the unknown unknowns and how can you deploy technology today or get it close enough? What are the lessons that this kind of approach, this innovative kind of moonshot-style approach, MBA students or startup founders, what are the tactics you use and how do we all employ them? Wow, that's a big question.

Well, let me start by describing GitHub Next and our place in the business, which is, I think, the most important place to start. The gentleman from Intercom earlier, I forgot his name, I'm sorry. He actually said, there's a separate team and they sit off to the side and they don't have red tape.

That's us. We are the department of long bets, or am I allowed to swear on stage? We're the department of fuck around and fuck up. And I don't care about the next six months.

Not because it's not important, but because there's other functions in the business and that's their job, right? Their job is to ensure that our revenue is still coming in, keeping the lights on. My job is not to be the regular brigades of the army, but to be the scouts. And scouts aren't equipped like the regular brigades and they don't behave like the regular brigades and that's

not better or worse, it's just a different function in the same way that legal is fulfilling a different function for the business than product.

So, our job is to find high impact, high leverage bets. If this sounds a lot like startups to you, then you're not wrong. In fact, you could just treat Git Up Next as, I mean, I hate to cite Chairman Mao, but like permanent startup, right? Permanent revolution.

We are charged with always figuring out what's going to disrupt us in one year, two years, five years, and try to get ahead of that and build up some experience with that and to de-risk things that the rest of the business would never do because it's too risky. Because they're like, oh, that sounds good, but we're not sure if there's a pot of gold at the end of that rainbow, why would we want to go on that adventure, right? Why would we want to check out if AI can help you code? Because our customers are not asking for this. They're asking for fixes to the stuff that's broken in our product today.

And so, maybe another way to think about this is that we're in an insurance policy, right? Bet 1% of the business on insuring that we don't. I mean, go read Christian's Innovator's Dilemma. You'll get a much better version of that from him.

But that's what we do. And then lessons learned about how we should operate. Matt, maybe give me a little guidance on which part of the tree you want to dig into first.

Like, how we hire and staff, how we select projects. Like, which part do you want to get into? Yeah, I think hiring is a great place to start. Well, we're a small team.

We're an unusual team in that everybody, it's like the Navy SEALs, right? Everybody on the team, there's no fresh out of school recruits on the team. Everybody needs to be an independent operator. I like to say, every soldier, a general.

Because we're entrusting them with a lot of freedom to go figure out what's good and then make it. So, I hire people that have a lot of experience, can credibly advance the state of the art, are self-sufficient. The key quality that I look for is, if I leave you alone for five minutes, do you make something? Because at the end of the day, there's a lot of people with philosophers bearing Google Docs.

And that doesn't not have value, but nothing speaks like a prototype. As much as my official title is research, it's not research, it's prototyping. Our job is to make.

And so I'm hiring makers of a lot of different skill sets. And generally, every one of those people tends to be a hybrid. Somebody who, when I ask them, listen, what are you good at? And they're like, well, I'm kind of good at this, but also that.

And that's great. I look for those interdisciplinary people, because very often, advancing the state of the art requires that ability to look across the boundaries of not just product, not just engineering, not just design, to puzzle out what's possible and then make it. And then show

other people.

Because at the end of the day, I measured on how many things escaped the lab. So my job is to roll up to corporate leadership and be like, here's a bet we should make, and here's why we should make it. And the way that we know that is because we built a small version of it.

Here's the scale model, and here's the results. So that's who we hire, and that's the mindset that I hire for. But you can copy-paste nearly anything about how to hire for early stage startups, and it would apply here.

I think that's really helpful and insightful. Before I do a follow-up here, I would encourage anyone to, if you have questions about anything we've been talking about along the way. Spicy questions.

Spicy, spicy. Extra picante questions, please queue our code, scan, and we'll see if we can have some time at the end for Q&A. So, other attributes that you might, I guess, we can glean insights from, are, how do you, what is the method, or if you have a rule of thumb, or like a protocol for finding what to pursue? I feel like these long, really kind of hard-to-convince people are worth the time.

And, you know, what leads, what leads as far in priority with those? I guess I'll start with, what's the potential? Just like startups. If you go to a venture capitalist and be like, I can build a fantastic 10 million a year ARR kind of product. They'll be like, okay, and what you want is a bank.

They're not interested in things that could not be a unicorn, and they will use every lever at their disposal to force you into that business mode. We are no different. We need to aim for only things that could have a high impact.

If it's not a huge potential thing, then why is the rest of the business not doing it? You know, if it's something that's closer to today. So that's the first thing that we look for. We think a lot about what's at the edge of what's possible, and we try to build things like that, because what's almost possible today at the rate, almost everything that we do now is around AI, because it would be idiotic not to use the largest lever that we can.

So with AI things, what's almost possible today will be really easy. The models will one-shot it in six months. So there, it's like if we do something that we can almost get working now, then in six months' time when the models can just do it, we'll be in pole position for executing that product, because we've already gained the know-how and the, there's a good German word for like what's that problem space and what's the solution space inside it.

So we look for things like that, but in terms of how we actually select, the process is kind of messy, and almost everything comes back to that hiring thing that I was talking about earlier. I'm hiring people that can credibly advance the state of the art, and so every Thursday, we have demo day. Every Thursday, people show off their things, and we expect people Almost always,

they have these ideas that are just trying to get out of them, and so it's a little bit like Google's mythical 20% time, but for real, because I don't think Google actually does this.

And one of the first signals that we look for is, is this exciting the other people in the room? You know, at a moment where the really futuristic ideas are sort of coming out of people, they're domain experts. They usually sound crazy. If they sounded good, there would already be a business around that.

So I'm looking for, like somebody shows something, and three other people are like, yeah, yeah, that. Let's do that. And that's the first signal.

And then, okay, we extend the lease of life of that effort, that project. I never staff things for like six months. It's like, okay, take a couple more weeks, and move the ball forward.

Build the next stage of the prototype, and then go try it out on other people at GitHub. Try it out on, you know, design partners outside of GitHub. And sort of this expanding circle of trying it out, getting data and feedback, iterating, figuring out if we have product market fit, just like every startup.

Over and over again until we have the evidence we need to persuade leadership to make the resource bet that they need to make to go big with it. So, yeah, it's basically that in the loop over and over again. That's great.

Startups. Startups. As we've heard all day today and everywhere in any type of media, AI is reshaping the types of roles and skills that are needed across almost every industry now, whether you're employing it or developing it, AI.

What advice would you give students or young professionals or, you know, startup founders that may be here today that want to position themselves in a landscape that they're not really sure that they fit into or how they fit into it yet and how to leverage it? That's normal. Like, I'd say, specifically for software engineers, I say, like, hey, do you feel stupid? Get used to that. Your entire career, that's how you're going to feel if you're doing it right.

On the product, in the product realm, that expresses itself as, you know, I'm not sure if this is the right direction. I'm not sure if this is the right product. I'm not sure, like, you know, make friends with that feeling because it never goes away so long as you're out there on a ledge looking for something that doesn't yet exist.

If you want safety, go work at a bank. You will definitely know what you're doing and what's expected of you and there will be no questions for you about what you should or shouldn't be doing and whether or not you're stupid or whatever. So, so, that.

The other thing is don't shy away from, God, this is going to sound terrible, but, like, intersectionality. Everybody remembers the first half of the jack-of-all-trades video? Everybody know the second half? And master? No, that's right. As a hybrid over the course of my career, a

lot of times I've stood in front of people that were asking me, like, listen, why should I hire you? You know, are you the best developer that has ever walked the face of the planet? I'm like, no.

Okay, so you must be like a really great designer. They're like, no, not that either. And they're like, great, so what value do you have? And I'm like, well, I can glue those functions together for you because I live with one foot in either side.

And just the ability to say, I am self-capable of going from zero to one. And today with AI, it's like wearing rocket boots for that purpose. I think hybridity was something that was undervalued in the past, and now it's actually a superpower.

So, like, don't shy away from it. Like, it's possible to succeed by deep specialization. That's valid.

But I think now is the age of hybrids so let's lean into that. I think that's really good advice. not the first time I've heard maybe countervailing advice today where earlier speakers say that folks have been pigeonholed over time via the education system into very narrow, niche, singular roles in society.

Pick a lane. Pick a lane. And now it's really important that you step out of the lane.

Thank you for highlighting that. We've got some time if you'd like to take some questions. Lots of great questions.

Spicy. All right, what's a spicy? Oh, you know what? This is spicy. If you could fire any CEO in the world, who would it be and why? Oh, my God.

You're on. You know what? I got what I asked for. Mark Benioff.

I feel like his leadership direction I used to work prior to GitHub, I worked at Heroku, which is a company that got acquired by Salesforce and so I got to see the sausage-making factory up close. You know, the style of innovation through acquisitions only. Yeah, I'm not a big fan of that.

You should grow that capability from inside if that's what you want to do. And it was this rotating cast of I care about this, no wait, now I care about that. You know, we were like, hi, our platform usage has tripled but our headcount is flat.

Please, sir, may we have some headcount? He was like, shh, I'm buying a slap now. And, like, I get it, but, you know, like, invest in the business you already have a bunch of kids, like, invest in them. Got what you asked for.

Okay. Okay, this is a great one, very, very relevant. How do you head balance picking features for power users focused on customization versus guided users, those that prefer simplicity and perhaps a little intimidated by the process.

I'm going to take that question and I'm going to judo flip it into a different question which is, I

think, the question that's hiding inside it. I think it's a question of audience. At GitHub, our audience is developers and for as long as GitHub has existed, our audience has been professional and hobbyist developers and not my uncle, right? We don't sell to consumers and so I think what that question is a proxy for is like, who do you, which market do you want to target? It's not about like beginner versus not beginner, it's like, do you want to go after a meaningful addition to the thing and if you look at GitHub's communications over the last, I don't know, two years, there was a whole phase there where the then CEO of GitHub was talking about a billion developers and, you know, how do we get to a future where there are a billion developers on the back of data and I think a lot of people interpreted that as like, oh, we're somehow going to create, you know, 999 million more of this guy? I don't, that's not possible, right? There aren't that many people who really want to learn the discipline of creating software.

I think a billion developers is more like Excel, right? That's a product that has a billion users but that's got a very different target audience so instead of thinking about sort of like power features versus not power features is who are you catering to and obviously you want the biggest possible total addressable market but large total addressable market is really hard to reason about. You know, I've got all these competing desires and features that people want inside that. It's a lot harder for me to empathize with my users.

Starting small is great it helps me be really crisp about what I'm doing and more importantly what I'm not doing because just saying yes to everything gets you nowhere real fast. So, we tend to focus at Next on the needs of the developer and even if I was going to go after a billion developers what I really want to do is like okay, let's go after developer adjacent personalities, personas, like product managers and designers and I don't know like technical product managers people who like manage game charts and stuff like that or project managers rather. Why? Because those are people that are already involved in the software development life cycle.

That's like that's the Hawaii in the middle of the ocean instead of me trying to go all the way to Asia from here. Like, why don't I go to the island that's like halfway to Hawaii first and then on the back of that I'll be smarter about how to cross the rest of the ocean. So, that's not exactly the question but I think that's how I think about it.

I think so. I think you tackled a lot of the questions. I get a big github specific question.

Do you want to take a spicy question or a github specific question? Spicy. What is the close to possible thing Too spicy? I'm just going to say it out loud. It makes more sense when I verbalize it.

Better questions. Come on guys. I'm going to skip it.

When there is a successful prototype that will be adopted, does the creator carry the project forward or hand off completely? You stepped directly on the biggest landmine. This is the

hardest part of my job over the last six years. And in any innovation team in a larger business, I'd say this is where the bodies are married.

Hand off. No word makes me sweat at night more than that word. Can you explain what a hand off is in development? In our case, we've incubated something to the MVP stage.

Now leadership is like, yeah, we love it, go, run fast, run far, go to market. And here's three teams from engineering to help you do it. That's usually when the project dies.

It's more nuanced. And I want to be clear about this. This is not because of bad intentions.

Nobody has bad intentions. This is the road to hell paved with all the good intentions. Hand off is tricky because in the early phases, when only you and your team understand the product, the people that are coming in need to understand the product like you do.

And very often they don't because they come from an engineering and product environment that says this is how we do things. And so they're going to try to impose a process and a mindset on you that maybe doesn't make sense for a new product category that hasn't been tried before. And then with the best of intentions, in the process of giving your baby up for adoption, oops, the baby died.

And that feels bad. It feels bad for your team and then you're also in a separate environment where you don't be for baby. And you don't have to be there the baby.

And then you don't have to be there for the And then you have to be there baby. And then you don't your And then the step is really making it better for After that, because Next represented a small subset of people that is capable of going from 0 to 1 in products like that, it's like, well, do you want to use these people to, like,

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